The news about Anderson's U-2 being overdue at the base reached the Joint Chiefs of Staff at 2:03 p.m. Forty-four minutes later, at 2:47 p.m., the Chief of Naval Operations Office Log recorded news of an announcement by the Cuban minister of defense that his forces "had fired at a hostile aircraft." By that time Anderson's U-2 was an hour overdue at his base, but there was no indication that the plane had been shot down. At 4:50 p.m. Admiral Charles Griffin, the deputy chief of naval operations, received a report about the downing of the plane. Immediately he ordered a revision of Plan 312 (Shoe Black), which contained instructions for "discriminatory retaliation in the event of shooting at reconnaissance aircraft." McNamara was notified soon afterward.

"Well, now this is much [more] of an escalation by them, isn't it?" were the first words uttered by President Kennedy on hearing the news. "Yes, exactly," responded McNamara. Kennedy was trying to make sense of what had just happened in the context of the two letters that Khrushchev had sent him in the last twenty-four hours. "How do we explain the effect of this Khrushchev message of last night and their decision [to shoot down an American plane]?" asked the president. "How do we interpret this?" responded McNamara. "I do not know how to interpret it."[14]

The dark room in which they were all operating as they tried to discern the rationale behind Khrushchev's contradictory letters had suddenly been darkened even more by the shocking news. The members of ExCom could not imagine that they were not the only ones losing control of their people on the ground and in the sky. Khrushchev was facing the same situation, and the consequences in his case were even more dangerous.